both of us were sitting on gigantic piles of nuclear weapons that were getting higher and higher and more and more dangerous, and I agreed. He wouldn't commit himself, but he left me with the impression that the Soviets might consider a return to the bargaining table. However, I think he didn't intend to do anything about that until after our election.

Following our meeting, I began devoting more time to the reelection campaign. I told George Shultz and the others to stick with our policies, and said that if I won the Russians would return to the table in Geneva.

George Shultz and Cap Weinberger were having one of their disputes over policy. Cap was not as interested as George in opening negotiating with the Russians, and some of his advisors at the Pentagon strongly opposed some of my ideas on arms control that George supported, including my hope for eventually eliminating all nuclear weapons from the world. Cap had allies among some of my more conservative political supporters, who let me know they thought Shultz had gone soft on the Russians and they wanted me to fire him—an idea, I told them, that was utter nonsense. Meanwhile, Bud McFarlane, who also sometimes differed with Cap and angered him by claiming the Pentagon could modernize its forces effectively at substantially lower cost than Cap was asking for, sided with George. Bill Casey and Ed Meese lined up in Cap's camp in favoring an even harder line toward the Russians, as this entry from my diary in November reflected: ". . . [the dispute] is so out of hand George sounds like he wants out. I can't let that happen. Actually George is carrying out my policy. I'm going to meet with Cap and Bill and lay it out to them. Won't be fun but has to be done." I didn't disagree with Weinberger that the Russians were an evil force in the world and untrustworthy, but I didn't think that meant we shouldn't talk to them.